

Steven Vanden Heuvel

Staff Product Designer · Design Systems & AI Tooling

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SUMMARY

Product designer who takes a flow from problem framing through interaction and visual design to handoff, and builds the tooling that makes the next one faster. 27 years of bringing new technique into industries early: responsive design in B2B publishing before it was standard, Atomic Design through Pattern Lab before the term design system was in common use, Figma around 2018, Storybook, and Claude Code and Cursor now. Most recently Principal Designer at PayPal on contract, designing merchant-facing payment flows for top global brands and the consumer checkout their customers see, and building a Figma plugin, adopted and in use, that cut merchant flow setup from most of a day to 10 to 15 minutes across the 38-merchant program. Spent 18 years at MTG Media Group, ending as VP and Creative Director, building and governing the design systems behind 6 responsive web products for 7 publication brands under one set of contribution rules that engineers outside the design team adopted. Four-time Jesse H. Neal Award winner, including Best Website in 2017.

SKILLS

Product Design, UX Design, UI Design, Interaction Design, Visual Design, Payments and Checkout, Financial Products, Internal Tools and Admin UX, Design Systems, Design Tokens, Atomic Design, Storybook, Responsive Web, Prototyping, Wireframing, Usability Testing, Accessibility (WCAG), Stakeholder Workshops, Figma, Figma Plugin Development, Figma REST API, HTML, CSS, Reading and Debugging JavaScript and Node.js, AI Assisted Development (Claude Code, Cursor, MCP)

EXPERIENCE

Principal Designer, PayPal

Dec 2025 to Aug 2026 | Remote, IL | Merchant Enablement Checkout (Contract)

- On my own initiative, built a Figma plugin that cut merchant flow setup from most of a day to 10 to 15 minutes across the 38-merchant program. PMs and designers had been using different words for the same flow elements, so the plugin made the flow skeleton a shared reference. Adopted and in use, published to the internal GitHub with video tutorials, and handed off to another designer to broaden. It was not fully scaled before the contract ended.
- Produced 20+ complete merchant proposal packages for PayPal's top 100 global brands on weekly sprints. The program's product manager credited the team with moving top accounts to integration or launch.
- Designed generic one-click checkout flows for grocery, retail, restaurant, and subscription merchants, mostly mobile, from product selection through payment confirmation, so one pattern set held across categories.
- Built the Figma board mapping the checkout dead end customers hit with no working card to pay, one of the most frequent checkout patterns, back to the earlier points where they could have fixed it. Structured it with Claude Code from a director's diagram and gathered screens from teams across the company. The work reached senior leadership and became the team's template for mapping the next flows.

VP / Creative Director (Design Systems & Web), MTG Media Group

Oct 2007 to May 2025 | Chicago, IL and remote | 18 years in responsive web, product, and design systems

Led a 6-person creative team across 7 publication brands and 6 responsive web products at MTG Media Group, building and owning the design system behind each of the 6 sites. Initiated the brand-site rebuilds and introduced mobile-first responsive design, Figma, and Atomic Design through Pattern Lab, and began the team's move to Storybook.js.

- Wrote one set of contribution rules and a review process that applied across the site design systems, and got them adopted by engineers who did not report to me.
- Interviewed stakeholders across editorial, sales, IT, and ownership before the Plate and Hotels rebuilds, ran task-based usability tests on Plate through UserTesting.com, and followed sessions and heatmaps in Google Analytics and Lucky Orange. When testers kept flagging registration as long and intrusive, redesigned the flow with the publisher to ask less up front and collect data over time; that flow became the base for Alt Meat registration.
- **Plate:** Won 2017 Jesse H. Neal Award for Best Website. Rebuilt as a responsive, mobile first product serving 42,000+ readers with 56,000+ monthly pageviews. 90% of subscribers reported the content shaped their purchasing decisions.
- **Project Blackbird (Plate):** Built an interactive oral history product with a dozen video interviews, original photography, and illustrations. Grand Jesse H. Neal Award nominee, top 4 nationally.
- **Alt Meat:** Launched a brand, magazine, and website from zero in under 8 weeks as the first major B2B publication in alternative protein. Grew to 22,000 registered users.

AWARDS

- Four-time Jesse H. Neal Award winner (the B2B equivalent of the Pulitzer Prize)
- Grand Jesse H. Neal Award nominee for Project Blackbird, top 4 nationally

EDUCATION

University of Wisconsin-Whitewater, B.A. in Art with emphasis in Graphic Design and Marketing